to the polls. Left-wing organizations are busing them." The same warning was blasted out to Likud supporters via SMS throughout the day. It was a naked, ugly appeal to racism. In fact there was no evidence of overwhelming voter turnout among Israel's Arab minority.

Netanyahu prides himself on his image as a pragmatic conservative, and a worldly one, a politician who knows how to represent Israel on the international stage. He has beaten back primary challenges from far-right Likud figures like Danny Danon and Moshe Feiglin by portraying himself as a more sensible, steady choice. Yet he discarded all of that in the waning hours of the campaign, channeling the worst elements of Israel's political culture. It earned him days of public rebuke from the White House, and scorn from his political opponents.

Yet it would also prove tremendously effective.

Netanyahu, the gambler

None of this should have been necessary, not when Netanyahu decided in December to dissolve his government and call for early elections.

The prime minister had been less than two years into his four-year term. He was not especially unpopular. His approval ratings were in the mid-thirties—unimpressive, compared to their wartime highs in the 70s, but also in line with his average. His coalition was an awkward mix of far-right and center-left parties, but it looked reasonably stable. Even his unhappiest partners seemed to lack the political courage to bolt the cabinet. But he took a gamble anyway with the nation-state law.

Even this shouldn't have demanded such drastic measures. Lapid and Livni had offered to back a revised bill that had removed some of the most offensive provisions (like the bit that stripped Arabic of its status as an official language). The prime minister refused. "They were merely the excuse for dissolving this Knesset. No one in Israel knows what this law is about," said Amit Segal, the chief political correspondent for Channel 2. "Netanyahu was the prime minister for six years, and he never took a step to promote these laws. So one can infer that this was merely an excuse for dissolving the Knesset."

Why did he need this excuse? Because of the fractious nature of Israel's political system. Lapid had become a problematic member of the coalition, sparring with Netanyahu over the budget and a plan to exempt first-time